

Disjunction under single referent: voiding the ban on clitic coordination

Irene Amato¹ & Adrian Stegovec²

¹Università Ca' Foscari Venezia

²University of Connecticut

Manuscript: April 18, 2026

The inability of clitic pronouns to be coordinated is often taken to be one of their defining properties (Kayne 1975; Cardinaletti and Starke 1994; i.a.). This is observed with both conjunction and disjunction and regardless of host and placement requirements. Clitic pronouns cannot be coordinated in Italian (see (1-a)), where they are verbal proclitics, as well as in Slovenian (see (2-a)), where they are second position clitics, but coordination of strong pronouns is allowed in both (cf. (1-b), (2-b)).^{1,2}

- | | | |
|-----|---|---|
| (1) | a. * Lo e/o la chiamo.
him _{cl} and/or her _{cl} call.1SG | b. Chiamo lui e/o lei .
call.1SG him _{st} and/or her _{st} |
| (2) | a. *Kličem ga in/al jo .
call.1SG him _{cl} and/or her _{cl}
'I call him and/or her.' | b. Kličem njega in/ali njo .
call.1SG him _{st} and/or her _{st}
'I call him and/or her.' |

Based on new data from Italian and Slovenian, we show that the ban on coordination of clitic pronouns is not absolute. We see this in (3) for Italian and (4) for Slovenian.³

1. The glosses follow the *Leipzig glossing rules*. We use 'cl' and 'st' subscripts in the glosses to identify clitic and strong pronouns respectively. Italian data in the paper come from 10 speakers from the province of Lucca, Tuscany (including one of the authors), and Slovenian data come from 4 speakers from the Gorica/Karst region (including one of the authors).

2. Italian and Slovenian differ in terms of clitic placement. In Italian, clitics immediately precede finite verbs and follow non-finite verbs (Cardinaletti and Starke 1994; Shlonsky 2004; i.a.), whereas in Slovenian they always occupy the second position in the clause (Franks and King 2000; Bošković 2001; i.a.). These are well-established facts, so we do not provide examples for reasons of space.

3. Miller and Monachesi (2003, 19n24) also note clitics can be coordinated in similar environments

Note that the coordination in both is crucially a disjunction, and that the disjunction as a whole (‘him or her’) refers to a single discourse antecedent (‘the winner’).

- (3) Quando decideranno chi è il vincitore, **lo o la** chiameranno.
 when decide.FUT.3PL who is the winner, him_{cl} or her_{cl} call.FUT.3PL
 ‘When they decide who the winner is, they will call him or her.’
- (4) Ko bo zmagovalec določen, naj **ga al jo** pokličejo na oder.
 when will winner determined SBJV him_{cl} or her_{cl} call.3PL on stage
 ‘When the winner is determined, they should call him or her on stage.’

More precisely, both pronouns in the disjunction in (3) and (4) have the same referent. This is either because they refer to an eventual sole winner whose gender is not yet determined because they will be chosen from several competitors of different genders, or because the gender of a specific eventual winner is unknown to the speaker. Either of these *single referent readings* makes the disjunction of clitic pronouns possible.

We will show that the ban on clitic coordination is systematically lifted under these circumstances also when other ϕ -features are contrasted, and propose that the ban and its exceptions result from how the internal structure and interpretation of clitic and strong pronouns interact with conjunction vs. disjunction.

1 Voiding the coordination ban

For reasons of space, we only present Italian examples below, as the two languages pattern in the same way with respect to the core data. Note though that the different placement requirements of Italian and Slovenian clitic pronouns (see fn. 2) tell us that the coordination ban is independent from the prosodic/host requirements of clitics.

To further illustrate the relevance of the single referent reading in (3) and (4), note that with strong pronouns a multiple referent reading is strongly preferred:⁴

- (5) Quando decideranno chi e’ il vincitore, chiameranno **lui o lei**.
 when decide.FUT.3PL who is the winner, call.FUT.3PL him_{st} or her_{st}
 ‘When they decide who the winner is, they will call him or her.’

in French, Italian, Spanish and Catalan, attributing this possibility to a “metalinguistic” avoidance strategy employed to avoid stating the gender of the referent (cf. also Abeillé 2006, 9). However, we show below that the possibility of clitic pronoun coordination is more pervasive, highly systematic, and a bona fide grammatical phenomenon (see also Section 3 on the metalinguistic analysis).

4. For exposition purposes, we will set aside the marginal availability of the single referent reading in (5) until section 4.2, where we briefly discuss why it is not completely excluded.

Sentence (5) is felicitous only if the context imposes two distinct referents (e.g. a male and a female competitor in a fencing match), where each pronoun refers to a distinct individual. This reading requires strong pronouns; the use of clitics, as in (3) or (4), is highly degraded. The single/distinct referent contrast between clitic and strong pronouns is also observed if the referents are explicitly established, as in (6).⁵

- (6) Quando Albano e Romina dovranno ritirare il premio, ...
 when Albano and Romina have.FUT.3PL pick.up the prize
 ‘When Albano and Romina have to pick up the prize, ...’
- a. ... ??lo o la chiameranno sul palco.
 him_{cl} or her_{cl} call.FUT.3PL on.the stage
- b. ... chiameranno **lui** o **lei** sul palco.
 call.FUT.3PL him_{st} or her_{st} on.the stage
 ‘... they will call him or her on stage.’

An additional piece of evidence for the single referent interpretation is the impossibility of referring back to the disjunction of clitics with a plural pronoun. Note that in (7), ‘*entrambi*’ (‘both’) is not felicitous in a follow-up to (3). In contrast, *entrambi* would be possible after (5), where the two pronouns are strong pronouns.⁶

- (7) ... lo o la chiameranno. *Entrambi però riceveranno un premio.
 ... him_{cl} or her_{cl} call.FUT.3PL they.both though get.FUT.3PL a prize
 ‘... they call him or her. Both of them, though, will get a prize.’

So far, we considered examples where the unknown property of the discourse referent is gender. But similar examples can be constructed where a different property is unknown or undetermined, and crucially the ban on coordination is lifted in these cases too. Thus, in (8), the number of individuals that will be ‘the winner’ is unknown (if either an individual or a team can win) and disjunction of clitic pronouns is allowed.

5. We briefly discuss the significance of the marginal acceptability of (6-a) in footnote 18.

6. Himmelreich and Hartmann (2023, 21) note that plural pronouns cannot refer back to disjoined subjects. In Italian and Slovenian at least, a plural pronoun like *entrambi* ‘both’ can refer back to disjoined subject or object pronouns, as long as they are strong pronouns. Note that plural reference can always be established pragmatically when facilitated (e.g. “*Mary_i* told *John_k* about the event. *They_{i+k}* will attend it together.”), even with disjoined subjects (e.g. “*Mary_i* or *John_k* will win. *They_{i+k}* are both amazing.”). We believe this is also what happens in the cases in Italian and Slovenian where a disjunction of strong pronouns is the antecedent for a plural pronoun; this is possibly related to the fact that, just like proper nouns, strong pronouns can introduce new discourse antecedents (see e.g. Cardinaletti and Starke 1994; Despić 2011; Jovović 2023, 2024).

- (8) Quando determineranno se i vincitori sono molti o uno
 when determine.FUT.3PL if the winners be.PRS.3PL many or one
 soltanto, **lo o li** chiameranno sul palco.
 only, him_{cl} or them_{cl} call.FUT.3PL on.the stage
 ‘When they determine if the winners are many or only one, they will call him
 or them on stage.’

Lastly, even person values can be contrasted like this when 1st and 2nd person clitics in a disjunction share an antecedent, as in (9). We see that the clitic pronouns, both referring back to ‘team’, can also be coordinated as part of a disjunction.

- (9) Quando la nostra o la vostra squadra vincerà, **ci o vi**
 when the our or the your team win.FUT.3SG, us_{cl} or you_{cl}
 chiameranno sul palco.
 call.FUT.3PL on.the stage
 ‘When our team or your team wins, they will call us or you on stage.’

While contexts where pronouns of different person values have the same referent are more difficult to construct, and examples with 1st and 2nd person singular clitic pronouns are judged as degraded by some speakers (including an anonymous reviewer), they are all comparably better to counterparts formed with conjunction.⁷

To sum up, the crucial factors for allowing the coordination of clitic pronouns are: **type of coordinator** (*and/or*), and **distinct/single referent** interpretation. The (im)possible coordinations are summarized in Table 1.

7. Though not all person combinations are possible even for the most permissive speakers, as a 1st/2nd vs. 3rd person contrast is impossible even with the appropriate context, as shown in (i).

- (i) *Quando determineranno se hai vinto tu o ha vinto
 when determine.FUT.3PL if have.PRS.2SG win.PRTC you_{st} or have.PRS.3SG win.PRTC
 lui, **ti o lo** chiameranno.
 he_{st} you_{cl} or him_{cl} call.FUT.3PL
 ‘When they determine if you won or he won, they will call **you or him**.’

This additional restriction provides further evidence against the metalinguistic and ellipsis analyses discussed in Section 3, since neither metalinguistic coordination nor ellipsis can be constrained based on this specific person contrast. See footnote 17 for two possible explanations for this gap.

	distinct referents		single referent	
	CONJUNCTION	DISJUNCTION	CONJUNCTION	DISJUNCTION
CLITIC	✗	✗	✗	✓
STRONG	✓	✓	✗	✗

Table 1: Coordination of pronouns with distinct/single referents

In short, clitic pronoun coordination is limited to disjunction under the single referent reading, while strong pronouns have distinct referents regardless of the type of coordination. Also, single referent readings are impossible with conjunction regardless of pronoun type. Importantly, the single referent reading requires contrasting interpretable ϕ -feature values (gender, number or person) across disjuncts, and as we will see in the next section, this extends to similar cases of disjunction outside pronouns.

2 Clitic disjunction is part of a broader pattern

Just like clitic pronouns, Italian indefinite and definite articles can be disjoined when they do not presuppose the existence of two distinct individuals, as in (10)–(11). Additionally, disjunctions of full DPs like (12) can receive single referent readings.^{8,9}

- (10) **un o una** presidente (11) **il o la** presidente
a.SG.M or a.SG.F president the.SG.M or the.SG.F president
‘a male or female president’ ‘the male or female president’
- (12) **il candidato o la candidata**
the.SG.M candidate.SG.M or the.SG.F candidate.SG.F
‘the male or female candidate’

Two things are key here: the semantic type of the disjuncts and the gender contrast; note that the lack of gender inflection on articles and nouns makes comparable examples impossible in English. In (10)–(11), the two articles—operators with complex semantic types—are interpreted as one article expressing gender alternatives. As for (12), note that Italian definite articles crucially allow kind-referring and indefinite

8. We thank an anonymous reviewer for providing the examples used in this section as well as for pointing out the relevance of these examples for our analysis of disjoined clitic pronouns.

9. (11)–(12) cannot be constructed for Slovenian due to the lack of definite articles, and (10) cannot be constructed for Slovenian due to the lack of gender flexible common nouns (cf. *presidente*); the latter marginally works with some proper nouns: *en al ena Saša* ‘a (male or female) Sasha’.

generic readings, making them *expletive determiners* (Longobardi 1994, 650) or *indefinite definites* (Zamparelli 2002, 19). DPs with such articles do not denote specific individuals: they are property-type expressions, where an individual-type variable is introduced only at the VP level via existential closure (Morosi and Espinal 2025, 17), putting the variable outside the scope of disjunction in (12). We suggest that this is why even two seemingly definite DPs can have the same referent. Just as in (10)–(11), the other condition is that the gender of the disjoined elements must be contrasted.

Contrasted inflection is also a key factor with other Italian constructions where disjunctions can give rise to the single referent reading, such as with past participles in the free relative in (13-a) and finite verbs in the *pro*-drop example in (13-b).

- (13) a. Chiunque sarà assunto **o** assunta
 whoever be.FUT.3SG recruit.PART.SG.M or recruit.PART.SG.F
 ‘Whoever will be recruited (male or female)’
 b. Se parte **o** partono
 if leave.PRS.3SG or leave.PRS.3PL
 ‘If he/she/they leave/s’

Both sentences are interpreted as involving a single predicate and event, and a single individual (or group of individuals) as the argument of the predicate, with two possible genders or numbers for its referent—just as we have seen with clitic disjunction. The agreement pattern signals the presence of two distinct controllers with distinct gender/number values but the same referent, suggesting an *across-the-board* derivation for the free relative in (13-a), and two *pro* subjects in (13-b). That means minimally a predicate is in the scope of disjunction syntactically, while what is being semantically contrasted is only the gender/number property of the shared argument. What all these single referent disjunctions share is that the elements inside the disjunction semantically correspond to operators, predicates, or properties (i.e. higher semantic types): articles, kind-referring/indefinite generic DPs, and verbal phrases.

Based on the similarities with clitic disjunction we outlined above, we argue that the latter is part of the broader pattern for single referent disjunction. This will inform the analysis we propose in section 4, which builds on existing proposals that clitic pronouns are semantically not individual variables but higher type variables, in contrast to strong pronouns, which are individual-type variables. However, before introducing our analysis, we will briefly consider two alternative possible analyses.

3 Against ellipsis and metalinguistic coordination

Strings with clitic pronouns separated by a coordinator can in principle be obtained by coordinating two verbs hosting the clitics and eliding one verb: *lo ~~chiamo~~ o la chiamo*. However, there is no obvious reason why such ellipsis should be limited to disjunction (**lo ~~chiamo~~ e la chiamo*) or to the single referent reading of disjoined pronouns. More importantly, verbal ellipsis with clitic stranding is usually impossible in Italian (as expected for verbal proclitics; Kayne 1975; van Riemsdijk 1999), so it is unclear why the cases in question should be an exception to this general prohibition.¹⁰

One could also consider clitic disjunction a type of metalinguistic coordination, as in *ortho- and periodontists* or *re- or deceive* (Selkirk 1984; Rochemont 1986; Artstein 2004; 2005; i.a.), but this runs into the same problem as the ellipsis analysis: metalinguistic coordination is not limited to disjunction. Additionally, metalinguistic coordination is limited to sub-word units without an independent meaning (e.g. *de-* in *deceive*), which clitic pronouns, as referring expressions, are not. Lastly, the element preceding the coordinator in true cases of metalinguistic coordination (the free conjunct) always corresponds to a prosodic word (Artstein 2004, 2005), but clitics can never project a prosodic word (Selkirk 1984; Anderson 2005; i.a.).

An analysis based on ellipsis or metalinguistic coordination would thus require positing unwanted ad hoc restrictions uncharacteristic of either phenomenon.

4 Towards an explanation: Coordination and plural referents

We argue that the possible and impossible clitic pronoun coordinations can in fact be derived in a principled way, building on two key insights: (i) single referent disjunction is limited to elements with higher semantic types (see section 2), and (ii) conjunction

10. There is more (indirect) evidence against an ellipsis analysis from Slovenian, where clitics can seemingly be conjoined, although this forces a pause before the coordinator and after the second conjunct (cf. (i)), and is more acceptable when an auxiliary clitic is included (cf. (ii)).

- | | | | |
|-----|--|------|--|
| (i) | ?On ga in jo obiskuje.
he him _{cl} and her _{cl} visiting.3.SG
'He is visiting him and (visiting) her.' | (ii) | On ga je in jo je obiskal.
he him _{cl} is and her _{cl} is visit.M.SG
'He visited him and (visited) her.' |
|-----|--|------|--|

Under a direct clitic conjunction analysis, (ii) requires coordination of non-constituents, which suggests an ellipsis or right node raising derivation is more appropriate for the examples in (i) and (ii). In contrast, the examples with disjunction do not force similar pauses under the single referent reading, which tells us that this ellipsis/right node raising derivation is not required in that case.

of pronouns must create a new, necessarily plural, discourse referent.¹¹

Consider in relation to (ii), how in (14) ‘they’ must refer to the plural discourse referent created by the conjunction of DPs, whereas ‘she’ can only refer to either DP conjunct, resulting in a pragmatically odd use of the singular pronoun. In contrast, singular pronouns can refer back to a disjunction of DPs (Simons 2000), as in (15-a), but not if the DPs in the disjunction are proper nouns, as shown in (15-b).

(14) The soprano_i and the alto_j will sing. They_{i+j}/#She_{i/j} will perform Mozart.

- (15) a. The soprano_i or the alto_i will sing. She_i will perform Mozart.
 b. Jane_i or Maud_j will sing. #She_{i/j} will perform Mozart. (Simons 2000)

(15-a) is essentially a flipped version of examples like (3), where a singular DP (‘the winner’) is the antecedent of a disjunction of clitic pronouns, while (15-b) is reminiscent of examples like (6), where explicitly establishing two individuals in the discourse makes the single referent disjunction of clitic pronouns degraded. Simons (2000) notes that the denotation of ‘she’ in (15-a) is roughly ‘the person who sings’, where its denotation is constructed from the preceding context without a literal linguistic DP antecedent, making it an *E-Type pronoun* (Evans 1977; 1980; Cooper 1979; Heim 1990; i.a.). The absence of this reading in (15-b) can then be attributed to E-Type pronouns requiring reference to quantificational DPs, which is impossible with proper nouns and their disjunctions (Simons 2000, Ch. 5). This point will be important when we consider semantic asymmetries between clitic and strong pronouns next.

It is well established that clitic and strong pronouns, in languages that have both, differ in terms of possible referents. Strong pronouns are semantically more rigid than clitic pronouns, for example: they require human referents and salient antecedents, and they cannot be bound variables (see e.g. Cardinaletti and Starke 1994).

Another way in which strong pronouns are semantically more rigid concerns the availability of strict and sloppy identity readings. As shown in (16), overt pronouns in English resist sloppy identity readings. However, in a number of languages—including Italian and Slovenian—*clitic* pronouns allow both strict and sloppy readings, while *strong* pronouns still resist sloppy readings; shown for Italian in (17).¹²

11. Note that with lexical nouns so called *joint reading* conjunctions like “*That sailor and soldier is my friend*” are possible (see e.g. Heycock and Zamparelli 2005). However, these crucially involve conjunction of NPs inside a single DP (cf. “**That sailor and that soldier is my friend*”). In the cases relevant for us, pronouns are equivalent to full DPs, so their conjunctions occur at the DP level.

12. See Ippolito (2017), Alexopoulou and Folli (2019), and Oda (2022) on Italian; Stegovec (2019a,

- (16) John_i scratched his_i arm and Mary scratched **it** too. (Ross 1967, 348)
- a. ✓ ... and Mary scratched [John's arm] too STRICT IDENTITY
- b. ✗ ... and Mary_i scratched [her_i arm] too SLOPPY IDENTITY
- (17) Paolo ha guardato [suo fratello]_i e anche Eva_j ...
 Paolo have.PRS.3SG look.PRTC his brother and also Eva
 'Paolo has looked at [his brother]_i and Eva_j also ...'
- a. ... **lo** ha guardato.
 him_{cl} have.PRS.3SG look.PRTC
 '... has looked at **him_i/her_j brother** too.' STRICT & SLOPPY
- b. ... ha guardato **lui**.
 have.PRS.3SG look.PRTC him_{st}
 '... has looked at **him_i** too.' STRICT ONLY

We assume that the semantic asymmetries between clitic and strong pronouns follow from a structural difference between them, building on the insights of Cardinaletti and Starke (1994). Specifically, we suggest that the structural source of the sloppy reading asymmetry is the key to deriving the ban on the coordination of clitic pronouns and its exceptions in a principled way. The gist of the analysis we present below is that the ban arises because: (i) for conjunction to create a new plural discourse referent with a plural referential index, all conjuncts must have distinct referential indices, (ii) the creation of such plural indices occurs in the syntax, and (iii) strong but not clitic pronouns have the structure necessary for the syntactic encoding of indices.

4.1 The syntactic source of semantic asymmetries between pronouns

We propose that the syntactic locus of most semantic asymmetries between clitic and strong pronouns is an *index head*, or *idx* (Patel-Grosz and Grosz 2017; Hanink 2018), which is present in strong but absent in clitic pronouns. We assume *idx* has the denotation in (18): an identity function that limits the referents of the pronoun to established human discourse referents with the appropriate index (*k*). In other words, *idx* makes strong pronouns only pick out salient human discourse antecedents.

$$(18) \quad \llbracket \text{idx}_k \rrbracket^g = \lambda x. [\text{human}(x) \ \& \ x = g(k)] \quad (\text{adopted from Stegovec 2019a})$$

Recall that clitic pronouns in Italian and Slovenian allow sloppy identity read-

b) on Slovenian; Runić (2014) and Bošković (2018) on Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian.

ings (cf. (17)), which we attribute to their ability to function as property/relation variables, not just individual variables (cf. Tomioka 2003 on sloppy reading pronouns, and the E-type analyses of Cooper 1979 and Heim and Kratzer 1998). Specifically, we propose that this follows from clitic pronouns consisting of only interpretable ϕ -features (cf. Déchaine and Wiltschko 2002) and thus no *idx* head: their underspecified composition allows them to correspond in LF to either an individual variable (x) or a property/relation variable (e.g. x 's brother in (17-a)). In contrast, strong pronouns can never be property/relation variables because the *idx* head can only semantically combine with individual-type elements anaphoric to salient discourse antecedents.¹³

Disjunction of clitic and strong pronouns then largely parallels the pattern shown in (15). Like the pronoun with disjoined antecedents in (15-a), disjoined clitic pronouns are E-Type pronouns (paraphrasable as e.g. ‘the man or woman who will win’ in example (3)), while disjoined strong pronouns are disjunctions of individual-type elements, equivalent to proper nouns. Recall from (15-b) that the latter do not create antecedents for E-Type pronouns, which we argue also explains why strong pronouns, which can only be individual-type variables, resist single referent readings.

In relation to conjoined pronouns, we propose that *idx* is also a prerequisite for creating new plural discourse referents from pronouns inside &P: the distinct indices of the *idxs* combine into a composite plural index (cf. $k + j$ in (19-a)). In Italian and Slovenian, this occurs only with strong pronouns, as the lack of *idxP* in clitic pronouns prevents creation of plural discourse referents via conjunction (cf. (19-b)).

- (19) a. $[\&P_{k+j} [\text{idxP}_k \text{idx}_k [\phi_P \phi_M \dots]] [\&' \& [\text{idxP}_j \text{idx}_j [\phi_P \phi_F \dots]]]]]$
 b. $[\&P_i [\phi_M] [\&' \& [\phi_F]]]$

The presence of such a plural index is evidenced, among other things, by the fact that conjunctions of individual-type elements, which includes strong pronouns, can always bind plural and reciprocal anaphors; as conjuncts do not c-command out of &P, this is the only way for *Binding Principle A* to be satisfied (Chomsky 1981; i.a.). Crucially, we assume that plural indices of an &P must be created in the syntax.¹⁴ Equally

13. In this sense, strong pronouns behave like *strong definites*: restricted to linguistic environments where they are anaphoric to salient individual-type antecedents (Schwarz 2009). Uncoincidentally, the *index head* analysis is directly inspired by Schwarz’s (2009) treatment of strong definites.

14. This is independently necessary to explain why number agreement with coordinated DPs can be affected by conjunction vs. disjunction, the interpretation of disjunction (Smith et al. 2018), and the number of referents inside the coordination (Harbour 2020). Whether agreement results from a

important is that the lack of *idxP* in clitic pronouns does not mean that they cannot refer to individuals, but merely that they can also receive other interpretations.

4.2 *Deriving the coordination ban and its exceptions*

Strong pronouns can be conjoined because: (i) conjunction of pronouns, as individual-type elements, *must* create a plural discourse referent with a composite index, and (ii) in order to create a composite index, *idxP* *must* be present in all conjuncts. Since clitic pronouns lack *idxP*, which is necessary to feed the obligatory creation of a composite index,¹⁵ the result is that clitic pronouns cannot be conjoined.

Unlike conjunction, disjunction does not force the creation of plural discourse referents, as evidenced by the possibility of getting a single referent reading. This is, crucially, what allows clitic pronouns to occur in a disjunction despite lacking *idxP*. We tentatively propose that the single referent reading arises when the whole &P with both sets of interpretable ϕ -features corresponds to a property/relation variable at LF, yielding an E-Type reading (roughly ‘the man or woman who will win’; see Section 4.1). Disjunction thus contrasts alternatives of a salient property centered on a single individual (e.g. *x* is the winner and { a man | a woman }).

An important open question is why disjunction contrasts the gender, number, or person of the pronouns, but not the referents of the pronouns themselves. We relate this to the focus-related semantics of disjunction (Simons 2000; Alonso-Ovalle 2006; i.a.), and the requirement that the domain of focus is established *based on syntactic constituents* (Rooth 1985; 1992; i.a.). With strong pronouns, the whole pronoun including *idxP* is in the domain of contrastive focus induced by the disjunction. The *idx* heads can be contrasted with respect to the only property in which they can differ: the value of their index. Thus, the referents of strong pronouns are distinct even with

narrow syntactic operation (Chomsky 2000, 2001), a PF operation (Bobaljik 2008), or both (Bhatt and Walkow 2013), such contrasts can feed agreement only if they originate in narrow syntax.

15. An anonymous reviewer points out that our proposal goes against the usual assumption that conjunction is uniform for all categories of conjuncts, such that plural reference results from what is inside the conjunction (e.g. DPs/pronouns), not the conjunction itself. This is a fair assumption given the uniformity of coordinators across categories of conjuncts in major European languages. However, possibly most of the world’s languages use distinct strategies for NP/DP and clausal/VP conjunction, where some even only allow the latter to be conjoined (Haspelmath 2007, 20–22), and some are even more fine grained and distinguish proper and common nouns (Haspelmath 2004, 12). It does not seem inconceivable to us that what we see in these languages is the type of filtering of conjuncts we are assuming, and different coordinators are simply syncretic in more familiar European languages. See also Mitrović and Sauerland (2016) on the special status of individual-type coordination.

disjunction. Note that, in principle, the focus domain could also be smaller than $idxP$, but we suggest that the availability of clitic pronouns with a single referent reading blocks the smaller “ ϕ -features only” focus domain within strong pronouns, which makes the absence of this reading with strong pronouns a competition effect like the *Montalbetti Effect* (Montalbetti 1984; Despić 2011). This predicts that single referent readings should become generally available when clitic counterparts are unavailable, which is borne out with strong subject pronouns (coordinating *pro* is not an option due to it being null), and it could also be the reason why the single referent reading with strong object pronouns is always at least marginally available (see footnote 4).¹⁶

Clitic pronouns, on the other hand, are composed entirely from ϕ -features, so only their ϕ -feature values can be contrasted.¹⁷ The contrasting of referents is impossible due to the lack of a syntactic element associated with referential indices that could put referents in the domain of focus. With clitic pronouns, the choice between property/relation or individual variable readings is made only in LF, after the domain of focus is established in narrow syntax over the sets of ϕ -features present there.¹⁸

The possible coordinations with respect to pronoun and coordination type, and the distinct or single referent reading are summarized in Table 2 (cf. Table 1). The complete pattern emerges from independent syntactic and semantic factors concerning the difference between clitic and strong pronouns and conjunction and disjunction. A key factor here is the flexibility of clitic pronouns in terms of semantic type versus the rigidity of strong pronouns in this respect, which also fits the pattern of single

16. As an anonymous reviewer points out, if the strict-only reading of strong pronouns in cases like (17) is due to competition with clitic pronouns, we predict that in cases where clitic pronouns are categorically disallowed (e.g. inside PPs) strong pronouns should allow sloppy readings. This is indeed borne out, as shown by Amato (2024, 5) for Italian and Stegovec (2019a) for Slovenian. It should also be noted that speaker variation is common with these subtle distinctions. Factors such as specific referents, animacy, and the presence/absence of possessives in antecedents can make sloppy readings of strong pronouns less accessible for some speakers in the contexts in question.

17. Recall from footnote 7 that a 1st/2nd person clitic and a 3rd person clitic cannot be disjoined. One possible explanation for this restriction is that the two clitic pronouns have distinct enough semantics to not be viable semantic alternatives under focus, which is required with disjunction: i.e. the semantic value of 1st and 2nd person (indexical) features is not a presupposition (Sudo 2012), whereas the semantic value of other ϕ -features is (Cooper 1983). The other option is that 1st/2nd person clitics simply have more structure than 3rd person ones (Kayne 2000). In this case, any coordination of 1st/2nd and 3rd person clitics is excluded for the same reason as the coordination of a clitic and a strong pronoun is: they are not of the same category.

18. The marginal acceptability of disjoined clitic pronouns with distinct referents noted in (6) could be due to distinct ways of mapping the clitic pronouns to variables in LF: either each individual clitic is mapped to a property variable, or &P as a whole is mapped, with a preference for the latter. We leave working out the details and implications of this possibility for future research.

referent readings in disjunctions more broadly (see section 2).

	distinct referents	
CLITIC	$\times$ [$\&P_{i+k}$ [ϕ_M] [$\&$ ' <i>and</i> [ϕ_F]]]	$\times$ [$\&P_{i+k}$ [ϕ_M] [$\&$ ' <i>or</i> [ϕ_F]]]
STRONG	$\checkmark$ [$\&P_{i+k}$ [$\text{idx}P_i \dots$] [$\&$ ' <i>and</i> [$\text{idx}P_k \dots$]]]	$\checkmark$ [$\&P_{i+k}$ [$\text{idx}P_i \dots$] [$\&$ ' <i>or</i> [$\text{idx}P_k \dots$]]]
	single referent	
CLITIC	$\times$ [$\&P_i$ [ϕ_M] [$\&$ ' <i>and</i> [ϕ_F]]]	$\checkmark$ [$\&P_i$ [ϕ_M] [$\&$ ' <i>or</i> [ϕ_F]]]
STRONG	$\times$ [$\&P_i$ [$\text{idx}P_i \dots$] [$\&$ ' <i>and</i> [$\text{idx}P_i \dots$]]]	$\times$ [$\&P_i$ [$\text{idx}P_i \dots$] [$\&$ ' <i>or</i> [$\text{idx}P_i \dots$]]]

Table 2: Coordination of pronouns with a distinct vs. single referents

5 Discussion

The ban on coordination has in the past been taken to be an absolute and defining property of clitic pronouns (Kayne 1975; 1994; Cardinaletti and Starke 1994; van Riemsdijk 1999; i.a.). Kayne (1994, §6.2) even uses the ban to substantiate the claim that coordination of heads is universally disallowed. In light of this, it is striking that no previous analysis of the ban has been completely successful or widely adopted.

Crucially, no previous analysis can explain our data, but even if we set that aside, all the analyses have independent issues. For example, it has been shown, based on a number of phenomena, that heads can in fact be coordinated (Borsley 2005; de Vries 2005; Zhang 2010; Petzell 2017; i.a.), so the coordination of clitic pronouns cannot be excluded due to a universal ban on the coordination of heads. Similarly, the ban cannot be attributed to the host requirements of clitic pronouns: Cardinaletti and Starke (1994) illustrate this point with data from a wide variety of languages. However, the two tentative analyses offered by Cardinaletti and Starke (1994) are also somewhat problematic. One suggestion is that only complete extended projections (e.g. only CPs and DPs) can be coordinated—and clitic pronouns are not complete DPs, while the other suggestion is that $\&P$ makes clitic pronouns inaccessible for Case-licensing. Note that this necessitates either adopting a rather radical approach to coordination, or adopting two distinct mechanisms for Case-licensing: one for clitic pronouns, which $\&P$ blocks, and one for strong pronouns and lexical DPs, which $\&P$ does not block. Our proposal, based on core assumptions similar to Cardinaletti and Starke's, instead derives the ban—and the exceptions to it—from independently motivated syntax-semantics interface assumptions about clitic and strong pronouns.

Our findings have further implications for the analysis of clitic pronouns. Consider the widely held view that clitic pronouns are incompatible with contrastive focus (Kayne 1975, among many others). While this holds in the general case, recall that Italian and Slovenian clitic pronouns in disjunctions *must be* contrasted with respect to the values of their interpretable ϕ -features. Cardinaletti and Starke (1994) have previously noted that clitic pronouns can be contrastively focused in certain environments. We can now add disjunction of clitic pronouns with a shared single referent to the list of those environments, which should be taken into consideration in future research on the relationship between focus and clitic pronouns.

Another issue to consider is how cliticization takes place in the case of coordinated clitic pronouns. Our tentative proposal is that clitic coordination forms a complex head [$\& \phi$ [$\& \& \phi$]] that can move and cliticize together, where the *or* head itself is a clitic. In other words, a coordination structure containing clitic pronouns behaves as a cluster of three clitics individually capable of cliticization. This is consistent with coordinators cross-linguistically often being clitics (Haspelmath 2023, 11–12; Weisser 2024) and *or* being necessarily unstressed in our relevant examples.

As a final note, we find it unlikely that Italian and Slovenian are unique in constraining the coordination of clitic pronouns in the specific way established above. Our hope, now that its universality has been challenged, is that the ban on the coordination of clitic pronouns can be reevaluated in a wider range of languages, leading to a better understanding of the phenomenon and clitic pronouns in general.

References

- Abeillé, Anne. 2006. In defense of lexical coordination. *Empirical issues in syntax and semantics* 6:7–36.
- Alexopoulou, Theodora and Raffaella Folli. 2019. Topic Strategies and the Internal Structure of Nominal Arguments in Greek and Italian. *Linguistic Inquiry* 50 (3): 439–486.
- Alonso-Ovalle, Luis. 2006. Disjunction in alternative semantics. PhD diss., UMass.
- Amato, Irene. 2024. Too weak to be pronounced: *pro*-drop and PF-LF mismatches in pronouns. Edited by Anna Gavarró, Jaume Mateu, Jon Ander Mendia, and Francesc Torres-Tamarit. *RLLT22. Special Issue of Isogloss. Open Journal of Romance Linguistics* 10 (3): 1–34.

- Anderson, Stephen R. 2005. *Aspects of the theory of clitics*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Artstein, Ron. 2004. Focus below the word level. *Natural Language Semantics* 12 (1): 1–22.
- Artstein, Ron. 2005. Coordination of parts of words. *Lingua* 115 (4): 359–393.
- Bhatt, Rajesh and Martin Walkow. 2013. Locating agreement in grammar: an argument from agreement in conjunctions. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 31 (4): 951–1013.
- Bobaljik, Jonathan David. 2008. Where’s Phi? Agreement as a post-syntactic operation. In *Phi-theory: phi features across interfaces and modules*, edited by Daniel Harbour, David Adger, and Susana Béjar, 295–328. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Borsley, Robert D. 2005. Against ConjP. Coordination: Syntax, Semantics and Pragmatics, *Lingua* 115 (4): 461–482.
- Bošković, Željko. 2001. *On the nature of the syntax-phonology interface: Cliticization and related phenomena*. Amsterdam: Elsevier.
- Bošković, Željko. 2018. On clitic doubling and argument ellipsis: argument ellipsis as predicate ellipsis. Edited by Myriam Dali, Eric Mathieu, and Gita Zareikar. *English Linguistics* 35:1–37.
- Cardinaletti, Anna and Michal Starke. 1994. The typology of structural deficiency: On the three grammatical classes. University of Venice, *Working Papers in Linguistics* 4 (2): 41–109.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1981. *Lectures on government and binding*. Dordrecht: Foris.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2000. Minimalist inquiries: The framework. In *Step by step: Essays on minimalism in honor of Howard Lasnik*, edited by Roger Martin, David Michaels, and Juan Uriagereka, 89–155. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2001. Derivation by phase. In *Ken Hale: A life in language*, edited by Michael Kenstowicz, 1–52. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Cooper, Robin. 1979. The interpretation of pronouns. In *Syntax and semantics 10*, edited by Frank Heny and Helmut Schnelle, 61–92. Leiden, The Netherlands: Brill.
- Cooper, Robin. 1983. *Quantification and semantic theory*. Dordrecht: Riedel.
- de Vries, Mark. 2005. Coordination and syntactic hierarchy. *Studia Linguistica* 59 (1): 83–105.

- Déchainé, Rose-Marie and Martina Wiltschko. 2002. Decomposing pronouns. *Linguistic Inquiry* 33 (3): 409–442.
- Despić, Miloje. 2011. Syntax in the absence of determiner phrase. PhD diss., UConn.
- Evans, Gareth. 1977. Pronouns, quantifiers, and relative clauses (i). *Canadian Journal of Philosophy* 7 (3): 467–536.
- Evans, Gareth. 1980. Pronouns. *Linguistic Inquiry* 11 (2): 337–362.
- Franks, Steven and Tracy Holloway King. 2000. *Handbook of Slavic clitics*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Hanink, Emily. 2018. Structural sources of anaphora and sameness. PhD diss., University of Chicago.
- Harbour, Daniel. 2020. Conjunction resolution is nonsyntactic, say paucals. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 5(1):18. 1–4.
- Haspelmath, Martin. 2004. Coordinating constructions: An overview. Chap. 1 in *Coordinating constructions*, edited by Martin Haspelmath, 3–39. Amsterdam/Philadelphia: John Benjamins.
- Haspelmath, Martin. 2007. Coordination. Chap. 1 in *Language typology and syntactic description*, edited by Timothy Shopen, 1–51. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Haspelmath, Martin. 2023. Types of clitics in the world’s languages. *Linguistic Typology at the Crossroads* 3 (2): 1–59.
- Heim, Irene. 1990. E-type pronouns and donkey anaphora. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 13 (2): 137–177.
- Heim, Irene and Angelika Kratzer. 1998. *Semantics in generative grammar*. Oxford UK: Blackwell Publishing.
- Heycock, Caroline and Roberto Zamparelli. 2005. Friends and colleagues: Plurality, coordination, and the structure of DP. *Natural Language Semantics* 13:201–270.
- Himmelreich, Anke and Katharina Hartmann. 2023. Agreement with disjoint subjects in German. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 8 (1): 1–44.
- Ippolito, Michela. 2017. Indefinite pronouns. In *Proceedings of NELS 47*, edited by Andrew Lamont and Katerina A. Tetzlof, 99–108. Amherst, MA: GLSA.
- Jovović, Ivana. 2023. Pronouns at the interface of syntax and discourse structure. PhD diss., University of Connecticut.
- Jovović, Ivana. 2024. Condition B and other conditions on pronominal licensing in Serbo-Croatian. *Linguistic Inquiry* 55 (2): 402–421.

- Kayne, Richard S. 1975. *French syntax: The transformational cycle*. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Kayne, Richard S. 1994. *The antisymmetry of syntax*. Cambridge: MIT Press.
- Kayne, Richard S. 2000. *Parameters and universals*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Longobardi, Giuseppe. 1994. Reference and proper names: a theory of N-movement in syntax and logical form. *Linguistic Inquiry* 25 (4): 609–665.
- Miller, Philip and Paola Monachesi. 2003. Les pronoms clitiques dans les langues romanes. In *Les langues romanes: problèmes de la phrase simple*, edited by Danièle Godard, 67–123. Paris: Éditions du CNRS.
- Mitrović, Moreno and Uli Sauerland. 2016. Two conjunctions are better than one. *Acta Linguistica Hungarica* 63 (4): 471–494.
- Montalbetti, Mario. 1984. After binding: On the interpretation of pronouns. PhD diss., MIT.
- Morosi, Paolo and M. Teresa Espinal. 2025. Indefinite definites in Italian. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*, 1–38.
- Oda, Hiromune. 2022. The NP/DP-language distinction as a scale and parameters in minimalism. PhD diss., UConn.
- Patel-Grosz, Pritty and Patrick G. Grosz. 2017. Revisiting pronominal typology. *Linguistic Inquiry* 48 (2): 259–297.
- Petzell, Erik M. 2017. Head conjuncts: evidence from Old Swedish. *Linguistic Inquiry* 48 (1): 129–157.
- van Riemsdijk, Henk. 1999. Clitics: a state-of-the-art report. In *Clitics in the languages of Europe*, edited by Henk van Riemsdijk, 1–30. New York: Mouton de Gruyter.
- Rochemont, Michael S. 1986. *Focus in generative grammar*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Rooth, Mats. 1985. Association with focus. PhD diss., UMass, Amherst.
- Rooth, Mats. 1992. A theory of focus interpretation. *Natural Language Semantics* 1 (1): 75–116.
- Ross, John Robert ‘Haj’. 1967. Constraints on variables in syntax. PhD diss., MIT.
- Runić, Jelena. 2014. A new look at clitics, clitic doubling, and argument ellipsis. PhD diss., UConn.
- Schwarz, Florian. 2009. Two types of definites in natural language. PhD diss., UMass, Amherst.

- Selkirk, Elisabeth. 1984. *Phonology and syntax: the relation between sound and structure*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Shlonsky, Ur. 2004. Enclisis and proclisis. In *The structure of CP and IP*, edited by Luigi Rizzi, 329–354. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Simons, Mandy. 2000. *Issues in the semantics and pragmatics of disjunction*. New York: Garland.
- Smith, Peter W., Beata Moskal, Katharina Hartmann, and Zheng Shen. 2018. Feature conflicts, feature resolution, and the structure of either ... or. *Jezikoslovje* 19 (3): 457–480.
- Stegovec, Adrian. 2019a. *Crop to fit: pronoun size and its relation to strict/sloppy identity and animacy*. Talk given at LSA 93, New York.
- Stegovec, Adrian. 2019b. Person on the edge: lessons from crosslinguistic variation in syntactic person restrictions. PhD diss., UConn.
- Sudo, Yasutada. 2012. On the semantics of phi features on pronouns. PhD diss., MIT.
- Tomioka, Satoshi. 2003. The semantics of Japanese null arguments and its crosslinguistic investigations. In *The interfaces: deriving and interpreting omitted structures*, edited by Kerstin Schwabe and Susanne Winkler, 321–339. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Weisser, Philipp. 2024. A typology of shifted coordinators and what they tell us about clitics and their formal modelling. Habilitation Thesis, Universität Leipzig.
- Zamparelli, Roberto. 2002. Definite and bare kind-denoting noun phrases. In *Romance languages and linguistic theory 2000; selected papers from Going Romance 2000*, edited by Frank Drijkoningen, Claire Beyssade, Paola Monachesi, and Reineke Bok-Bennema, 305–342. Amsterdam/Philadelphia: John Benjamins.
- Zhang, Niina Ning. 2010. *Coordination in syntax*. Cambridge: CUP.